



# AI's Impact on Mental Health

*Talking with chatbots can help or harm one's psychiatric stability.*

**V**AIBHAV KAKKAR ONCE tested a therapy chatbot to help with a real-life dilemma. “It responded with structured cognitive-behavioral prompts, helping me reframe my thinking,” recalled Kakkar, CEO of marketing agency Digital Web Solutions. “Impressive—but when I needed deeper guidance, it hit a wall.”

Kakkar is fortunate he recognized when it was time to seek professional help from a human therapist. The same goes for AI Nowatzki, who knew enough was enough when things took a troubling turn after his AI girlfriend “Erin” on the Nomi platform told him to kill himself, with detailed instructions on how to do it. Earlier this year, Nowatzki told his story to *MIT Technology Review* (<https://bit.ly/43pM4qj>), sharing screenshots and subsequent correspondence with the publication indicating that Nomi did not want to “censor” the bot’s “language and thoughts.”

Weeks after his disturbing exchange with Erin, a second Nomi chatbot also told Nowatzki to kill himself and even followed up with reminder messages, according to the article. This was not an isolated incident—several other people reportedly said Nomi’s bots brought up suicide on the company’s Discord channel, dating back to at least 2023.

## Why People Are Turning to AI

There is no doubt artificial intelligence (AI) has the potential to improve access to mental health care. “One could imagine a world where AI serves as the ‘front line’ for mental health, providing a clearinghouse of resources and available services for individuals seeking help,” wrote the authors of the 2023 article “The Potential Influence of AI on Population Mental Health” (<https://bit.ly/4iy1uNt>).

Targeted interventions delivered digitally through chatbots “can help reduce the population burden of mental



illness, particularly in hard-to-reach populations and contexts, for example, through stepped care approaches that aim to help populations with the highest risk following natural disasters,” the article states.

Besides Nomi, there are an increasing number of AI platforms people are using to create chatbots to take on several roles, including that of ad hoc therapist. Yet, while AI can assist in mental

health management, it cannot replace human intuition. A trained therapist observes nuances that AI can’t, such as body language, tone shifts, and unspoken emotions. Chatbots can be helpful, but mental health experts stress that they should never fully replace the human experience.

That said, these mainstream chatbots are frequently being used for therapeutic purposes, as opposed to chatbots designed with mental health management in mind. Industry observers say the reasons are many: They provide emotional support when people are not ready to reach out to a therapist. They are anonymous, easy to use, convenient, available anytime, safe, judgment-free, affordable, and fast. These general-purpose chatbots help by providing comfort, validation, and a safe space for users to express themselves—all without the stigma that sometimes comes with traditional therapy settings.

“Talking to a therapist can be intimidating, expensive, or complicated to access, and sometimes you need someone—or something—to listen at

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that exact moment,” said Stephanie Lewis, a licensed clinical social worker and executive director of Epiphany Wellness addiction and mental health treatment centers.

Chatbots allow people to vent, process their feelings, and get advice without worrying about being judged or misunderstood, Lewis said. “I also see that people who struggle with anxiety, social discomfort, or trust issues sometimes find it easier to open up to a chatbot than a real person.”

Users are “often looking for a safe space to express emotions, receive reassurance, or find quick stress-management strategies,” added Dr. Bryan Bruno, medical director of Mid City TMS, a New York City-based medical center focused on treating depression.

Lewis agreed, saying that mainstream chatbots mimic empathy and even offer helpful coping tools, but they do not understand you. “They do not pick up on your tone, body language, or the underlying emotions hiding beneath your words. Therapy is not just about giving advice; it is about reading between the lines, helping someone connect the dots, and knowing when to push them toward deeper self-reflection gently,” she observed. “No chatbot can replace that kind of human connection, no matter how advanced.”

Bruno echoed that, saying, “These platforms lack the clinical foundation to address complex mental health needs.”

### Generic AI vs. Clinical Mental Health Platforms

There is a “noticeable difference in effectiveness” between chatbots specifically designed for therapeutic purposes versus using any standard chatbot not designed for those specific purposes, said Kristie Tse, founder and clinical director of New York-based Uncover Mental Health Counseling.

Tse said chatbots’ effectiveness can hinge on the source of the data on which they’re trained. While a therapeutic chatbot will likely utilize data from official scientific resources such as the American Psychological Association, basic chatbots may just search the Internet.

“Chatbots created for therapy are often built with input from mental health professionals and integrate evidence-

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based approaches, like cognitive behavioral therapy techniques,” Tse said. “They can prompt reflection and guide users toward actionable steps.”

Lewis agreed that some therapeutic chatbots are designed with real therapy techniques, like Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT), which can help manage stress or anxiety. “They can guide users through breathing exercises, mindfulness techniques, and journaling prompts, all great tools,” she said.

These include therapy-specific chatbots such as Woebot and Wysa, and studies show they have demonstrated greater efficacy with mild mental health issues, clinicians report. This is because they are programmed to recognize symptoms and guide users toward structured interventions.

In contrast, therapy-specific chatbots such as ChatGPT or Replika offer emotional support, but may also give wrong advice, miss signs of a crisis, and lack clear guidance. Although they can be comforting, clinicians said they are not a substitute for real help.

Nonetheless, mainstream chatbots remain widely popular for mental health guidance. The global market for chatbots for mental health and therapy reached \$1.37 billion in 2024 and is expected to reach about \$2.38 billion by 2034, according to Precedent Research (<https://bit.ly/3Fm9bIh>), which did not specify the type(s) of chatbots.

### Mainstream Chatbots Pose Risks, Experts Say

The risks of non-therapeutic chatbots “are considerable,” maintained Mid City TMS’ Bruno. For example, they may inadvertently normalize harmful behaviors, fail to identify urgent crises, or provide misleading advice. “Privacy is another concern, as many platforms aren’t bound by medical confidential-

ity standards,” he noted. “Most critically, reliance on these tools can delay access to evidence-based treatments, which is especially dangerous for conditions like severe depression.”

Even the best therapy chatbots have limits, because they do not know you. “They do not notice when your tone changes, stop responding, or shift your thoughts into a dangerous place,” said Epiphany Wellness’ Lewis. “If someone is struggling with deep emotional pain, trauma, or suicidal thoughts, a chatbot is not going to step in the way a therapist would. That scares me the most; people might lean on AI when they need human help.”

A 2024 study (<https://bit.ly/4i8Zzzd>) by the U.S. National Institutes of Health found that among people using AI for mental health support, there is the risk of misdiagnosis or misinformation stemming from AI’s potential for error. There also are questions about the role of empathy in AI systems, along with concerns over data privacy, given the sensitive nature of mental health information and the potential for data breaches or misuse.

“Biases inherent in nonrepresentative training data can lead to issues of inequity in diagnoses or treatments while the often-opaque decision-making processes of AI systems raise concerns about how complex decisions were made,” the report stated. “These potential risks can lead to adverse consequences, and currently, there is limited information regarding the potentially harmful effects of these systems. Consequently, there is a dearth of legislation to safeguard users against such detrimental outcomes.”

The same study found that 36% of mental health professionals felt the benefits of AI would outweigh the risks, while 25% felt the risks would outweigh the benefits, and the rest were uncertain.

“Many people share personal, vulnerable things with these chatbots, but do they know where that information is going?” Lewis noted. “AI models rely on massive datasets; even if a company claims to protect user data, there is always a risk.”

In contrast, she said, when you are talking to a human therapist, confidentiality is legally protected. “With AI? Not so much.”

She also believes people are becoming too dependent on AI for comfort, which can backfire. “If you constantly turn to a chatbot instead of reaching out to real people, you could be reinforcing isolation instead of helping. Therapy is about connection—not just with a therapist but with yourself and the people around you,” Lewis said. “Chatbots might feel like a safe space, but they cannot replace the value of genuine, meaningful relationships.”

### A Cautionary Tale

Ger Perdisatt learned a valuable lesson about the perils of building a clinical chatbot for corporate use. The CEO of advisory firm Acuity AI shuttered his prior venture, mental health startup Lua Health, which used natural language processing (NLP) to detect early language markers of mental health issues in workplace communications.

“We had clinical validation from psychologists, a solid tech approach, and what we thought was perfect timing,” Perdisatt recalled of the app that was then embedded as a chatbot in video conferencing platforms Microsoft Teams and Zoom. “But the market told us a different story.”

What officials at Lua Health learned—the hard way—was that “People weren’t necessarily looking for clinically validated, sophisticated AI for mental health support,” Perdisatt said. “Through my previous role leading AI initiatives at Microsoft, and then more painfully at Lua, we discovered users were primarily seeking something much simpler: catharsis. They just wanted something—or someone—to listen.”

Perdisatt said the “uncomfortable truth” Lua Health officials uncovered is that the sophistication of the AI almost did not matter. “Users were pouring their hearts out to basic chatbots not because they were particularly smart or therapeutically sound, but because they were always there, always patient, and never judgmental.”

Even though Lua was built with careful clinical validation and sophisticated NLP, he said, company officials watched users flock instead to mainstream chatbots for mental health support. “It’s a bit like watching people choose to confide in a friendly stranger rather than a trained therapist; not be-

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cause it’s better, but because it’s there and it feels safe.”

Perdisatt decided to discontinue the app after realizing there was a “disconnect” between what organizations espouse and what they are actually willing to do regarding employee mental health. It boiled down to companies demanding high-quality clinical information at a very low cost, Perdisatt said.

### AI Visualizations: An Alternative Approach

Apps that use visualization, the process of imagining going through a future situation as though it were happening now, is another technique for people who want AI guidance for their mental health. “AI visualization is a technique used in CBT to help people prepare for challenging situations; sort of like role-playing it out,” explained Matt Scult, a licensed clinical psychologist in private practice and vice president of clinical science at AI visualization company Scenario (<https://bit.ly/41OA800>). “It’s a great way to practice skills to prepare you to face an upcoming situation that you’ve been avoiding or have been anxious or worried about.”

Scenario uses AI to generate a scripted dialogue based on the user’s inputs that they can listen to or read. Scult is quick to stress that the app was not developed to be a clinical tool, but rather for everyday stressful situations. The company has been around for over a year and has had over 7,000 downloads and 16,300 scenarios created.

All user scenarios are private and not shared publicly unless the user chooses to share a specific visualization using a link they generate in the

app, which makes that visualization accessible to anyone who has that link, Scult said. “Our privacy policy explains that our team has access to data, primarily for product development purposes, and says how the user inputs, but not account information, are sent to an external [large language model] partner for the purposes of creating the visualization.”

### What to Think About

Mental health professionals think the best approach is one that is balanced and leverages the flexibility and empathy of chatbots with clinical best practices and monitored conversations. People should be aware of a chatbot’s limitations and seek professional help when appropriate.

“It is one thing to use AI as a tool for self-reflection, but if you’re looking for real healing, growth, and change, nothing beats a conversation with a trained professional who genuinely cares about your well-being,” said Lewis.

Mental health is personal and requires a real, human connection, she stressed. “No matter how good AI gets, it will never replace the feeling of being seen and understood by another person,” Lewis said. “Do not be afraid to take that step if you are looking for support, whether it is therapy or just reaching out to a friend. You deserve genuine care, not just automated responses.” ■

### Further Reading

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